

LESSON 3

THE NARRATIVE PAST: THE PEAL PERFECT AND VERB SYNTAX

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 2

Quick Summary In Lesson 2, we moved our verbless clauses into the active present tense using the **Peal Active Participle** (e.g.,

KĀTEB

, “writing”). We learned that by attaching shortened enclitic pronouns to the participle (

- NĀ

,

- T

,

- ḤNAN

), Syriac forms the equivalent of the English present continuous (

KĀTEB-NĀ

, “I am writing”).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill (*Answers in Section 9*) 1. What is the m.sg. active participle of the root ‘-b-d (to do/make)? 2. How would you say “We are going” (root: ‘-z-l, enclitic: -ḥnan)? 3. Translate: Šām ‘īn-tūn meltā d-Alāhā. 4. What happens to the enclitic pronoun in the 3rd person plural (hennōn/hennēn) present tense? 5. Write “She is writing” using the root k-t-b and the 3rd f.sg pronoun.

SECTION 2: THE SEMITIC PERFECT TENSE — OVERVIEW

While the participle covers the present, the **Perfect tense** covers the past (completed action). The Perfect is formed by adding *suffixes* to the root to indicate person, gender, and number. It is therefore often called the “Suffix Conjugation.”

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: The Suffix Conjugation The Perfect tense behaves almost identically across the major Semitic languages. The core pattern is a C-a-C-a-C vocalization in the 3rd m.sg (or similar variant) followed by distinct suffixes for “I”, “you”, “we”, “they”. * **Hebrew Qal Perfect:** כָּתַב (kātab — he wrote), כָּתַבְתִּי (kātabtī — I wrote). * **Arabic Form I Perfect:** كَتَبَ (kataba — he wrote), كَتَبْتُ (katabtu — I wrote). * **Syriac Peal Perfect:** ܟܬܒ (ktab — he wrote), ܟܬܒܬ (ketbet — I wrote). * **Greek/Latin:** Greek Aorist (ἔγραψα) or Latin Perfect (scripsi) serve similar functions for completed past narrative actions, but without the triliteral root morphology.

SECTION 3: THE PEAL PERFECT & NARRATIVE SYNTAX

Forming the Peal Perfect For a strong root like *k-t-b* (write), the 3rd person masculine singular is the base form: **ktab** (he wrote). Notice the vocalization shift from the Hebrew/Arabic *a-a* to the Syriac *zero-a* (k-t-a-b) due to vowel reduction. The suffixes are added directly to the root: * Root + *-et* (1st person) → *ketb-et* (I wrote). * Root + *-ū* (3rd m.pl) → *ktab-ū* (They wrote).

Narrative Syntax: V-S-O Word Order Syriac is a heavily VSO (Verb-Subject-Object) language in past narrative. When reading historical or biblical texts, the verb will almost always come first. * *Ktab Yūḥannan meltā*. (Wrote Yukhannan a word → Yukhannan wrote a word).

The Conjunction w- (And) Syriac narratives chain countless actions together using the attached conjunction **w-** (and). “And he went... and he saw... and he wrote.” * *W-nfaq Yūḥannan w-ḥza malkā*. (And Yukhannan went out and saw the king).

SECTION 4: PERFECT TENSE PARADIGMS

1. The Peal Perfect Conjugation (Root **k-t-b**)

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	TRANSLATION	ARABIC COGNATE SUFFIX	HEBREW COGNATE SUFFIX
3 m.sg.	ܠܚܬ	ktab	he wrote	kataba (ﻛﺘﺎﺏ)	kātab (ﻛָּטַב)
3 f.sg.	ܠܚܬܐ	ketbat	she wrote	katabat (ﻛﺘﺒﺖ)	kātbāh (ﻛָּטְבָּהּ)
2 m.sg.	ܠܚܬܐ	ktabt	you (m) wrote	katabta (ﻛﺘﺒﺖ)	kātabtā (ﻛָּטַבְתָּ)
2 f.sg.	ܠܚܬܐ	ktabtī	you (f) wrote	katabti (ﻛﺘﺒﺘﻲ)	kātabt (ﻛָּטַבְתִּי)
1 c.sg.	ܠܚܬܐ	ketbet	I wrote	katabtu (ﻛﺘﺒﺘﻰ)	kātabtī (ﻛָּטַבְתִּי)
3 m.pl.	ܠܚܬܐ	ktabū	they (m) wrote	kabū (ﻛﺘﺒﻮ)	kābū (ﻛָּטְבוּ)
3 f.pl.	ܠܚܬܐ	ktabī	they (f) wrote	katabna (ﻛﺘﺒﻨﺎ)	-
2 m.pl.	ܠܚܬܐܢ	ktabtūn	you (m.pl) wrote	katabtum (ﻛﺘﺒﺘﻢ)	ktabtem (ﻛָּטַבְתֶּם)
2 f.pl.	ܠܚܬܐܢ	ktabtēn	you (f.pl) wrote	-	-
1 c.pl.	ܠܚܬܐ	ktabn	we wrote	katabnā (ﻛﺘﺒְּנָא)	kātabnū (ﻛָּטַבְנוּ)

Orthography Note: Notice how the single letter Taw (ܬ) represents both **-t** (you, m) and **-et** (I). Context and pointing (if present) clarify the reading.

SECTION 5: NARRATIVE WORD ORDER EXAMPLES

VERB	SUBJECT	OBJECT	TRANSLATION
ܠܚܬ	ܝܘܚܢܢ	ܡܠܬܐ	Yukhannan wrote a word.
ktab	Yūḥannan	meltā	
ܬܠܥܬ	ܬܠܡܝܕܐ	ܩܠܐ	The disciples heard a voice.
šma ‘ ū	talmīdē	qālā	

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (STRONG VERBS & TRANSITIONS)

ROOT	PEAL PERFECT (3 M.S.)	MEANING	TRANSITIONS	MEANING
מ.ב.ע	shbaq (שבע)	to leave, abandon	ו (w-)	and
מ.צ.י	nfaq (נצח)	to go out, exit	כ (kad)	when, while
י.נ.ר	nṭar (נטר)	to keep, watch	ג (gēr)	for, because (Greek γάρ)
מ.ק.ב	qreb (קרב)	to draw near	ת (tūb)	again, furthermore
פ.ר.ד	rdap (רדף)	to pursue	ע (hāyden)	then, at that time
פ.ל.ש	flaḥ (פלש)	to serve, work	ד (dēn)	but, however (Greek δε)
ש.ג.ד	sgad (שגד)	to worship, bow		
מ.ד.ל	qṭal (מל)	to kill		
פ.ר.צ	fraḡ (פרצ)	to save, rescue		
מ.ר.ח	‘raq (חר)	to flee		
ל.י.ד	dyāl (לד)	to give birth		
ח.מ.ד	‘aqar (חמד)	to root out, dig		
מ.ל.ס	sālaq (סלס)	to ascend, climb		

SECTION 7: THE STORY – PART 3

The Journey Narrative note: *The story now utilizes the VSO narrative chain to describe Yūkhannan’s past actions, transitioning from the immediate present tense of Part 2.*

Sentence 1 וּכְהֵנֶּה מֵעַמָּהּ כַּד וְכַד וְכַד w-kad ’emar hānēn, nfaq Yūḥannan. w-kad (and-when) ’emar (he-said) hānēn (these-[things]), nfaq (went-out) Yūḥannan (John). → And when he said these things, Yūkhannan went out.

Sentence 2 ,תאבאח םאבא ךאכא ןאכא w- 'ezal Yūḥannan
b- 'ar 'ā, w-shbaq talmīdāw-hy. w- (and-) 'ezal (went) Yūḥannan (John)
b- (in) 'ar 'ā (the-earth), w- (and-) shbaq (he-left) talmīdāw-hy (his-
disciples). → And Yukhannan went in the earth, and he left his disciples.

Sentence 3 ןאכא ךאכא ןאכא ןאכא nṭar Yūḥannan nūhrā b- 'ūrḥā.
nṭar (he-kept) Yūḥannan (John) nūhrā (light) b- (in) 'ūrḥā (the-way/
road). → Yukhannan kept light in the road.

Sentence 4 ןאכא ןאכא ןאכא ןאכא w-qreb Yūḥannan l-
malkūttā d-malkā bīšā. w- (and-) qreb (drew-near) Yūḥannan (John) l-
(to) malkūttā (the-kingdom) d- (of) malkā (the-king) bīšā (evil). → And
Yukhannan drew near to the kingdom of the evil king.

Sentence 5 ןאכא ןאכא ןאכא ןאכא w-rabbā d-malkā rdap l-
Yūḥannan. w- (and-) rabbā (the-great-one) d- (of) malkā (the-king) rdap
(pursued) l- (to) Yūḥannan (John). → And the great one of the king
pursued Yukhannan.

Sentence 6 ןאכא ןאכא ןאכא ןאכא w- 'raq
Yūḥannan w-qām qdām tar 'ā d-malkūttā. w- (and-) 'raq (fled)
Yūḥannan (John) w- (and-) qām (stood) qdām (before) tar 'ā (gate) d- (of)
malkūttā (the-kingdom). → And Yukhannan fled and stood before the gate
of the kingdom.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Perfect Identification Identify the person, gender, and number of the following verbs in the Perfect tense. 1. ןאכא (ktabū) 2. ןאכא (shbaqt - assuming 2nd m.sg) 3. ןאכא (neṭrat - assuming 3rd f.sg) 4. ןאכא ('raqn)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill Conjugate the root *p-l-ḥ* (to serve) in the following forms of the Peal Perfect: 1. He served 2. They (m) served 3. I served 4. You all (m) served

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English) Translate the following past narrative clauses. 1. W-shbaq Yūḥannan l-malkā. 2. Rdapū talmīdē l-bīšā. 3. Nfaq malkā dēn men tar ʿ ā. 4. Ktabn meltā d-Alāhā.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac) Render the following past narrative sentences into Syriac transliteration. Use VSO order! 1. The evil man fled from the light. (Use **men** for “from”). 2. And Yukhannan kept the word of God. 3. When the disciples drew near, they worshipped (*sgadū*). 4. The great king saved the earth.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension Re-read Section 7 and answer: 1. Who did Yukhannan leave behind when he went out? 2. What did the “great one” of the king do? 3. Where did Yukhannan stand at the end of the passage?

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up 1. ʿ ābed 2. ʿ āzlīn-ḥnan 3. You all (pl) are hearing the word of God. 4. It is not used. The plural participle ending (*-īn / -ān*) already marks the plural unambiguously. 5. Kātbā-hī (or just *Kātbā*).

Exercise 1: Perfect Identification 1. 3.m.pl (They wrote) 2. 2.m.sg (You wrote) 3. 3.f.sg (She kept) 4. 1.c.pl (We fled)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill 1. flaḥ 2. plaḥū 3. pelḥet 4. plaḥtūn

Exercise 3: Translation Drill 1. And Yukhannan left/abandoned the king. 2. The disciples pursued the evil man. 3. But the king went out from the gate. 4. We wrote the word of God.

Exercise 4: Production Drill 1. 'raq barnāšā bīšā men nūhrā. 2. W-ntar Yūḥannan meltā d-Alāhā. 3. Kad qrebū talmīdē, sgadū. 4. Fraḡ malkā rabbā l- 'ar ' ā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension 1. His disciples (*talmīdāw-hy*). 2. He pursued (*rdap*) Yūkhannan. 3. Before the gate of the kingdom (*qdām tar ' ā d-malkūtā*).

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

THE PEAL PERFECT (Root š-b-q)

PERSON	SYRIAC	TRANSLIT
3 m.sg.	ܫܒܩܬ	shbaq (he left)
3 f.sg.	ܫܒܩܬܐ	šebqat (she left)
2 m.sg.	ܫܒܩܬܝ	shbaqt (you left)
1 c.sg.	ܫܒܩܬܝܐ	šebqet (I left)
3 m.pl.	ܫܒܩܬܘܢ	shbaqū (they left)
1 c.pl.	ܫܒܩܬܡܢ	shbaqn (we left)

VSO RULE

1. VERB	2. SUBJECT	3. OBJECT / PREPOSITION
Nfaq (Went out)	Malka (The King)	men (from) 'ar ' ā (the earth)

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson's vocabulary, focusing on nouns related to narrative past (perfect tense) action and contexts.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܦܠܬܐ	pəlküttā	f. noun	flight, escape	from root p-l-k (to flee)
ܩܬܠܐ	qəṭlüttā	f. noun	slaughter, killing	from root q-ṭ-l (to kill)
ܕܥܒܕܐ	gənūbüttā	f. noun	theft, stealing	from root g-n-b (to steal)
ܫܒܩܐ	šəbūqüttā	f. noun	abandonment, leaving	from root š-b-q (to leave)
ܢܦܩܐ	napəqüttā	f. noun	going out, exit	from root n-p-q (to go out)
ܕܡܥܐ	dəm ‘ üttā	f. noun	weeping, tears	from root d-m- ‘ (to weep)
ܚܡܡܐ	ḥəmmüttā	f. noun	heat, fervor	from root ḥ-m-m m (to be hot)
ܦܥܓܐ	pəg ‘ üttā	f. noun	striking, blow	from root p-g- ‘ (to strike)
ܥܩܬܐ	‘ əqüttā	f. noun	flight, fleeing	from root ‘ -r-q (to flee)
ܩܪܒܐ	qərbüttā	f. noun	drawing near, approach	from root q-r-b (to draw near)
ܪܥܕܦܐ	rədupüttā	f. noun	pursuit, chasing	from root r-d-p (to pursue)
ܥܠܩܬܐ	‘ əlqüttā	f. noun	ascent, rising	from root ‘ -l-q (to ascend)
ܦܠܗܐ	pəlhüttā	f. noun	service, labor	from root p-l-ḥ (to serve)
ܕܪܥܐ	dərəküttā	f. noun	treading, passage	from root d-r-k (to tread)
ܥܡܕܐ	‘ amdā	m. noun	pillar, column	
ܦܪܓܢܐ	pərgānā	m. noun	authority, ruler	
ܪܥܡܐ	rəgmüttā	f. noun	stoning, lapidation	from root r-g- m (to stone)
ܫܡܪܐ	šəmrüttā	f. noun	guarding, keeping	from root š-m-r (to guard)

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܢܬܪܬܐ	nəṭrūtā	f. noun	watching, guarding	from root n-ṭ-r (to watch)
ܟܘܘܬܐ	kūwūtā	f. noun	substance, being	from root k-w- n (to be)
ܣܒܥܘܬܐ	səb'ūtā	f. noun	satisfaction, plenty	from root s-b-' (to be satisfied)
ܓܪܒܘܬܐ	gərbūtā	f. noun	scraping, scratching	from root g-r-b (to scrape)
ܠܓܕܘܬܐ	ləgdūtā	f. noun	seizing, capture	from root l-g-d (to seize)
ܫܘܒܩܢܐ	šūbqānā	m. noun	(one) abandoned	from root š-b-q (to leave)
ܐܫܬܓܠ	'aštəgal	verb	he was occupied	Pael perfect form
ܡܘܡܟܢܐ	pūmkānā	m. noun	speaker	from root p-w- m (to open mouth)
ܓܠܕܘܬܐ	gəldūtā	f. noun	uncovering, nakedness	from root g-l-d (to strip)
ܬܘܒ	tūb	adverb	again, furthermore	common particle
ܥܕܡܐ	'edāmā	preposition	until, as far as	used in past narrative
ܡܕܒܪܐܢܐ	mədbərānā	m. noun	leader, guide	from root d-b-r (to lead)